

Mountain ranges

Moving continents push layers of rock together to create mountains.



Mount Everest

The highest land peak on planet Earth, 29,029 ft (8,848 m) high and capped with limestone, was formed over tens of millions of years.

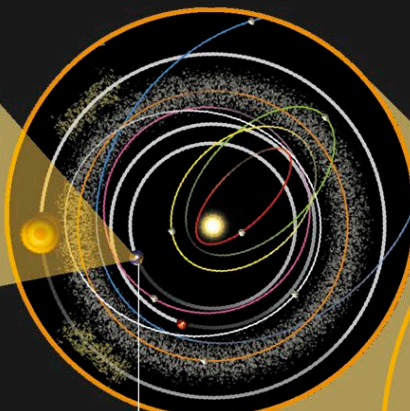
Earth

The third planet from the sun formed more than 4 billion years ago. Its diameter at the equator is 7,926 miles (12,756 km)—nearly 1,500 times Mount Everest's height.



Solar system

Eight planets orbit our sun, which has a diameter 100 times bigger than Earth's. The edge of the solar system is 122 times as far from the sun as the sun is from Earth.



Earth to sun

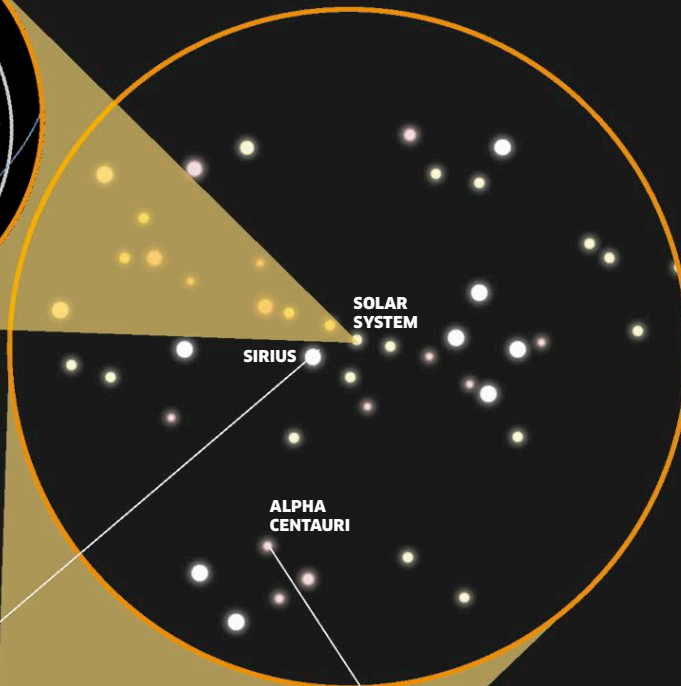
The distance between Earth and the sun is 93 million miles (150 million km). This is known as one astronomical unit (AU).

Binary system

Star systems that have two stars, such as Sirius, are called binary systems.

Stellar neighborhood

There are 79 star systems in our stellar neighborhood—all within a range of 20 light-years. The closest, Alpha Centauri, is 4.35 light-years away. Most systems have one star, but some, such as Sirius, glow brightly with two.



Brightest stars

Alpha Centauri is one of the brightest stars visible from Earth, apart from the sun. Others are Sirius and Procyon.

Far-flung solar system

Our solar system is about 26,000 light-years from the center of our galaxy.

Galaxy

Galaxies are enormous groups of stars that are held together by the force of gravity but separated by distances millions of times bigger than the distances between planets in our solar system. Our sun is on one of the spiral arms of a galaxy called the Milky Way, which is 100,000 light-years across—small for a galaxy.

MILKY WAY

